

Lifelong Opportunity Guide 70 — Travel Agent and Travel Coordinator

Version: 2.0 controlled working master

Language: English

Occupation benchmark: O*NET-SOC 41-3041.00 — Travel Agents

Canada comparison: NOC 64310 — Travel counsellors

Review date: 2026-08-21

What this career is

Travel agents and travel coordinators help people or organizations plan and arrange transportation, accommodations, itineraries, tours, and related services. They may advise clients, compare options, quote prices, make reservations, collect or route payments, document preferences, solve travel disruptions, and communicate with airlines, hotels, tour operators, ground-transportation providers, insurers, and other suppliers.

This guide uses **O*NET-SOC 41-3041.00 — Travel Agents** as the primary U.S. occupational benchmark. The title **Travel Agent and Travel Coordinator** is intentionally broad because employers use different titles for overlapping work. Leisure travel agents often sell trips directly to consumers. Corporate travel coordinators may arrange employee travel for a company, university, government entity, nonprofit, or managed travel program. Some workers specialize in cruises, groups, luxury travel, destination weddings, student travel, meetings, humanitarian travel, or specific regions.

A travel title does **not** automatically authorize someone to act as an immigration adviser, lawyer, medical professional, customs officer, border official, security officer, financial adviser, insurance producer, or government representative. Entry, visa, health, safety, taxation, insurance, and documentation questions must be handled within the worker's actual authority and verified through current official sources.

Why this role can be an opportunity

The occupation can be accessible to people with strong customer service, communication, sales, organization, research, and computer skills. In the United States, BLS reports that a high school diploma or equivalent is typically sufficient for entry, although employers may prefer sales experience, relevant education, or industry credentials. Moderate-term on-the-job training is typical.

The work can suit people who enjoy helping others, coordinating many details, comparing options, learning destinations, and solving problems

under time pressure. It can also create pathways toward corporate travel, account management, group travel, tour operations, supplier relations, meetings and events, travel technology, quality assurance, operations, sales leadership, or travel-program management.

The role also has pressure points. Travel changes quickly. Workers may have to respond to cancellations, weather events, schedule changes, overbooking, missed connections, documentation problems, supplier failures, or client emergencies. Peak periods, time zones, urgent changes, and customer frustration can make the work demanding.

Typical responsibilities

Depending on the employer and specialty, a travel agent or coordinator may:

- discuss destination, dates, budget, accessibility needs, preferences, loyalty programs, and travel purpose;
- research flights, rail, lodging, vehicles, transfers, tours, cruises, or packaged travel;
- compare fares, rules, cancellation conditions, baggage terms, and supplier restrictions;
- build and revise itineraries;
- make, change, or cancel reservations within delegated authority;
- issue or coordinate tickets and confirmations;
- calculate trip costs and explain what is or is not included;
- collect or route payments using approved systems;
- maintain traveler, supplier, reservation, and transaction records;
- communicate schedule changes and important supplier information;
- support clients during delays, cancellations, missed connections, rebooking, or other disruptions;
- coordinate corporate travel under employer policy, preferred-supplier rules, approval limits, and expense requirements;
- document exceptions and escalations;
- explain general travel procedures without inventing legal or immigration advice;
- remind clients to verify passports, visas, entry rules, vaccination or health requirements, and destination advisories with authoritative sources;
- support group manifests, rooming lists, traveler profiles, or meeting travel logistics where assigned;
- protect payment, identity, passport, itinerary, loyalty-account, contact, and location information;
- follow refund, exchange, chargeback, fraud, and supplier-escalation procedures;

- use approved reservation, CRM, office, expense, and communication systems;
- record notes accurately enough that another authorized worker can continue the case;
- escalate urgent safety, fraud, data, harassment, trafficking, or security concerns through employer procedures.

Authority and professional boundaries

Do not assume that a travel-agent or coordinator title gives authority to:

- guarantee entry to any country;
- interpret immigration law or provide legal representation unless separately qualified and authorized;
- promise that a visa, passport, waiver, permit, or travel document will be approved;
- state that a destination is safe without checking current official advisories and context;
- provide medical advice, diagnose travel-health risks, prescribe medications, or replace a clinician or official health source;
- override airline, hotel, cruise, rail, insurance, government, payment-card, or employer rules;
- alter payment information, traveler identity, loyalty credentials, or booking records without authorization;
- disclose a client's itinerary, hotel, travel dates, passport data, payment information, phone number, home address, employer travel plans, or other personal data to an unverified person;
- use a client's payment card outside approved payment processes;
- share passwords, reuse another person's credentials, or bypass multifactor authentication;
- create fictitious confirmations, letters, invoices, vouchers, or supporting documents;
- hide fare conditions, cancellation rules, commissions, fees, supplier restrictions, or known limitations from the client;
- tell a traveler to ignore border, customs, airline, safety, security, or public-health requirements;
- use AI output as the sole authority for visa, border, health, legal, safety, refund, or supplier-rule decisions.

When the correct action is unclear, pause the transaction and escalate to the designated supervisor, travel-program manager, supplier support desk, payment team, legal/compliance function, security team, or official government source.

Work environment

Travel work is commonly computer- and phone-intensive. Workers may spend long periods seated, monitor multiple systems, and handle simultaneous calls, chats, emails, or booking requests. Corporate travel teams may work with employees in multiple time zones. Leisure agents may work evenings or weekends to meet client needs. Some roles are office-based, some hybrid, and some remote, but remote work still requires secure systems, reliable connectivity, privacy controls, and employer approval.

Workers may experience:

- high-detail reservation and ticketing work;
- frequent use of email, CRM, reservation, payment, and supplier portals;
- deadlines and rapid itinerary changes;
- emotionally charged conversations during disruptions;
- sales goals, service metrics, or quality targets;
- irregular or extended hours during emergencies and peak travel periods;
- time-zone coordination;
- repeated exposure to personal, financial, passport, and location data;
- pressure to move quickly while still following security and documentation rules.

A realistic job preview, informational interview, short internship, or customer-service role can help a learner decide whether the pace and detail level fit before paying for specialized training.

Skills employers value

Customer and communication skills

- active listening;
- clear written and verbal communication;
- professional telephone and messaging etiquette;
- customer-service recovery;
- cultural awareness and respectful communication;
- calm problem solving;
- expectation setting;
- conflict de-escalation;
- accurate explanation of fare, supplier, and employer rules;
- language skills where relevant to the market served.

Travel and coordination skills

- itinerary planning;

- reservation research;
- fare and rate comparison;
- schedule interpretation;
- supplier coordination;
- ticketing and confirmation accuracy;
- cancellation and rebooking procedures;
- documentation of client preferences and approvals;
- group or corporate travel coordination;
- expense-policy awareness;
- escalation during disruptions.

Technology skills

O*NET identifies travel and reservation technology as important to the occupation. Depending on the employer, systems may include:

- **Amadeus;**
- **Sabre;**
- airline, hotel, cruise, rail, tour, and rental-car supplier portals;
- CRM platforms;
- Microsoft Office, Excel, Outlook, and related office tools;
- corporate expense or travel-management systems such as SAP Concur;
- approved chat, email, telephony, and collaboration tools.

A system name on a job posting is not a universal legal credential. Employers may train workers internally, require prior GDS experience, or use proprietary platforms.

Work habits

- attention to detail;
- accurate recordkeeping;
- punctuality and follow-through;
- calm prioritization;
- willingness to verify rather than guess;
- protection of client and payment information;
- consistent use of approved systems;
- careful handoffs;
- documentation of changes and client approvals;
- willingness to escalate when authority is unclear.

Education and entry pathways — United States

BLS reports that a **high school diploma or equivalent** is typically required for travel agents, with **moderate-term on-the-job training**.

Employers may prefer candidates with sales experience, customer-service experience, travel knowledge, or relevant certification or education.

A low-cost progression can be:

1. strengthen customer-service, email, spreadsheet, telephone, research, and documentation skills;
2. learn basic geography, time zones, airport codes, travel terminology, and supplier structures;
3. build privacy, cybersecurity, fraud, payment-card, and identity-verification awareness;
4. practice comparing transportation and accommodation options using public information without handling real client data;
5. apply for entry roles such as travel advisor trainee, reservations agent, travel support specialist, customer-service representative, corporate travel assistant, or scheduling coordinator;
6. learn the employer's reservation, GDS, CRM, payment, refund, and escalation procedures;
7. request cross-training in rebooking, groups, corporate travel, account support, quality, or supplier relations;
8. pursue paid credentials only after confirming that target employers value them.

Private travel-school tuition is not automatically necessary for entry. Compare employer-paid training, public colleges, community colleges, workforce programs, industry training, and short courses before taking on debt.

Funding, free/low-cost training, and work-based learning — United States

CareerOneStop and American Job Centers

Use the **CareerOneStop WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder** to locate state-approved programs that may qualify for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act support:

[Source link](#)

WIOA eligibility, provider approval, supportive services, and available funding vary by state and individual circumstances. Funding is not automatic.

American Job Centers may provide free career services, job-search help, training referrals, accessibility support, and information about local workforce funding.

Employer-supported learning

Ask employers whether they provide:

- paid onboarding;
- GDS or reservation-system training;
- destination and supplier training;
- quality and customer-service coaching;
- payment-security and fraud training;
- privacy and cybersecurity training;
- language development;
- tuition reimbursement;
- cross-training in corporate, leisure, group, or meetings travel;
- mentoring or job rotation.

For this occupation, structured on-the-job training, trainee roles, internships, and employer-sponsored systems training may be more common than a formal Registered Apprenticeship. Do not describe a role as a registered apprenticeship unless the sponsor and program can be verified.

United States pay and outlook

Official BLS benchmark

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reports:

- **Median annual wage: \$48,450** in May 2024;
- **Median hourly equivalent: \$23.29;**
- **Employment:** about **65,700** jobs in 2024;
- **Projected employment, 2034:** about **67,200;**
- **Projected growth: 2% from 2024 to 2034;**
- **Projected openings:** about **7,100 per year** on average over the decade.

BLS notes that travel agents work in travel arrangement and reservation services and that some are self-employed. Compensation can vary by employer, commissions, specialty, market, schedule, and sales model.

Current non-government estimate — Indeed

Indeed reported an average U.S. travel-agent base salary of **\$21.62 per hour**, with a displayed range of about **\$14.23 to \$32.85 per hour**, based on 212 salary/job-posting data points over the prior 36 months and updated **August 1, 2026**.

This is a **non-government market estimate**, not an official wage statistic and not a guaranteed offer. Use it only as a current comparison point alongside BLS data and actual job postings.

Canada pathway

Canada classifies **Travel counsellors** under **NOC 64310**. Job Bank describes the occupation as advising clients on travel options and tour packages, making bookings and reservations, preparing tickets, and receiving payment. Employers include travel agencies, transportation and tourism firms, and hotel chains.

Job Bank indicates that this occupation usually requires secondary school or specific training / several weeks of on-the-job training, depending on the role.

Canada wages

Job Bank's Canada-wide wage data, updated November 19, 2025, shows:

- **Low:** C\$17.50/hour;
- **Median:** C\$24.00/hour;
- **High:** C\$35.00/hour.

The reference period is 2023-2024 and the source is the Statistics Canada Labour Force Survey. Provincial, territorial, city, employer, commission, and experience differences can be substantial.

Canada training and financial support

Government of Canada training resources include:

- training finders for short-term, paid, or free courses;
- student grants and loans;
- Employment Insurance rules for people taking approved training;
- provincial and territorial training and employment programs;
- Labour Market Development Agreement and Workforce Development Agreement supports.

Start here:

Source link

Eligibility varies. Do not assume that a course is funded or that EI can continue during training without checking the applicable rules.

Colombia pathway

SENA — Servicios de agencias de viajes

SENA Betowa lists **SERVICIOS DE AGENCIAS DE VIAJES** as a titled **Técnico** program with a listed duration of **1,760 hours**.

The program identifies skills including:

- customer service under service policies;
- written and listening English;
- design of tourism programs according to market/client requirements;
- handling values and income related to operations;
- social and workplace interaction;
- a practical learning stage.

Source: [Source link](#)

SENA admissions, schedules, locations, and seats change. A program page can exist even when no cohort is currently open, so learners should verify live Betowa availability before making plans.

Complementary SENA options

Depending on current availability, SENA also lists tourism-related complementary learning such as:

- **Manejo de la información turística;**
- **Fundamentación en gestión del turismo;**
- **Legislación turística;**
- **Aplicación de buenas prácticas en turismo sostenible para agencias de viajes operadoras.**

These can support targeted skill building but do not by themselves guarantee employment, licensure, promotion, or a specific wage.

Colombia market-pay context — clearly labelled

Current non-government signals vary substantially by employer and city.

Indeed's July 2026 city comparison showed **Bogotá at approximately COP 2,122,065 per month** for travel agents, based on 64 reported salaries. A current Bogotá job posting surfaced at **COP 2,200,000 per month plus statutory benefits** for an agent role requiring tourism-related technical/technologist education and travel-agency experience.

These are **non-government market estimates/job-posting signals**, not official wage statistics and not guaranteed compensation. Corporate travel,

bilingual work, GDS depth, commissions, sales targets, shifts, and specialized accounts can materially change pay.

Latin America pathway

Across Latin America, training structures differ by country. Useful starting points include:

- national vocational-training institutions;
- ministries of labour, education, or tourism;
- public technical institutes;
- public employment services;
- tourism chambers and employer academies;
- airline, hotel, cruise, GDS, and tour-operator training;
- ILO/Cinterfor-connected vocational training institutions.

Learners should verify whether a program is public, subsidized, employer-paid, accredited, or fee-based before enrolling. A regional directory is a discovery route, not proof that a specific course, scholarship, or job is currently open.

Responsible AI in travel work

AI can help with low-risk support tasks such as:

- brainstorming itinerary structures;
- drafting plain-language client questions;
- summarizing non-sensitive supplier information;
- creating checklists;
- suggesting research categories;
- proofreading routine communication;
- generating training scenarios with fictional data.

AI should **not** be trusted as the sole authority for:

- visa or immigration requirements;
- passport validity rules;
- customs or border rules;
- travel advisories;
- health or vaccination requirements;
- supplier ticketing/refund rules;
- insurance coverage determinations;
- legal rights;
- emergency instructions;
- real-time availability or pricing unless connected to an approved authoritative system.

Never paste unapproved client passport numbers, payment-card details, loyalty credentials, medical details, full itineraries, employer travel plans, or other sensitive data into public AI tools.

A safe pattern is: **use AI to assist with drafting or organizing, then verify consequential facts with the current official government, carrier, supplier, or employer system before acting.**

Privacy, cybersecurity, and fraud

Travel work can expose workers to high-value personal and financial information. Risks include phishing, account takeover, fake supplier messages, fraudulent payment changes, social engineering, loyalty-account theft, refund scams, impersonation, and itinerary disclosure.

Good practice includes:

- use only approved devices and accounts;
- use multifactor authentication where required;
- never share passwords;
- verify unusual payment or bank-detail changes through approved channels;
- do not send full payment-card data through unapproved email or chat;
- verify identity before changing sensitive traveler information;
- minimize passport or identity-document copies and retain them only under policy;
- restrict itinerary and traveler-location information to people with a legitimate business need;
- report suspected phishing, fraud, account compromise, or data exposure promptly;
- lock screens and protect printed records;
- follow employer retention and deletion rules;
- do not move client data to personal accounts, personal cloud storage, or unapproved AI systems.

Accessibility and inclusive service

Travelers may have mobility, hearing, vision, cognitive, communication, dietary, medical-device, or other access needs. The worker's role is to ask respectful functional questions, document needs accurately, and coordinate with suppliers using approved processes.

Do not promise that an airline, hotel, ship, vehicle, tour, or venue can meet an accessibility need until the supplier has confirmed it. Do not diagnose a disability or demand unnecessary medical details. Escalate specialized accommodation questions and encourage direct supplier confirmation when appropriate.

Useful habits include:

- offer information in clear, structured language;
- confirm critical dates, times, airports, terminals, and assistance requests in writing;
- ask how the traveler prefers to communicate;
- avoid assumptions about what a person can or cannot do;
- confirm accessible rooms, transfers, seating, mobility-device handling, or assistance directly with the supplier;
- leave adequate connection time when accessibility support may require it;
- document supplier confirmation numbers where available.

Safety and disruption handling

During a disruption:

1. confirm the traveler's immediate situation and safety;
2. use official carrier, supplier, employer, and government channels;
3. verify what can actually be changed under fare and policy rules;
4. prioritize urgent needs within delegated authority;
5. document approvals, changes, and costs;
6. communicate realistic options without promising outcomes you cannot control;
7. escalate safety, medical, security, trafficking, fraud, or legal concerns to the appropriate function or emergency authority.

Do not tell a traveler to enter a closed area, ignore police or airport instructions, evade border controls, or misrepresent facts to a carrier or government official.

Building experience without overspending

A practical portfolio can use fictional or public-data exercises such as:

- compare three travel options under a fixed budget;
- build a sample itinerary with time zones and connection times;
- create a disruption-recovery decision tree;
- write a client-information checklist that minimizes sensitive data;
- compare refundable versus non-refundable conditions using public supplier examples;
- build a corporate travel request workflow with approvals and expense limits;
- create a privacy and phishing checklist for a fictional travel agency;
- practice explaining why visa and health rules must be verified with official authorities.

Do not place real customer, passport, payment, or employer data in a public portfolio.

Interview preparation

Be ready to explain how you would:

- clarify a client's needs before recommending options;
- check details before issuing or confirming travel;
- handle an upset traveler during a cancellation;
- protect payment and passport information;
- respond to a suspicious request to change payment or contact details;
- use a reservation or GDS system you have learned;
- verify visa, health, or destination rules without guessing;
- document a complex rebooking so another agent can continue the case;
- balance sales/service goals with policy compliance;
- support a traveler with an accessibility request.

If you lack direct travel-industry experience, use examples from customer service, scheduling, logistics, call centers, hospitality, events, administration, or other detail-intensive work.

Questions to ask an employer

- Which reservation or GDS systems do you use?
- Is initial systems training paid?
- Is the role leisure, corporate, groups, meetings, or mixed?
- How are commissions, incentives, or service fees structured?
- What quality and sales metrics apply?
- What are the shift, weekend, holiday, and after-hours expectations?
- Who handles emergencies outside normal hours?
- What is the escalation path for visa, safety, fraud, payment, and refund questions?
- What privacy and payment-security training is provided?
- Are there opportunities for cross-training or progression?
- Which expenses, credentials, or equipment must the worker pay for personally?

Before paying for training

Verify:

- whether target employers actually require the credential;
- total tuition, exam, subscription, textbook, and software costs;
- whether GDS practice access is included;

- refund and cancellation rules;
- whether employer-paid training exists;
- whether WIOA, public-college aid, Canadian provincial support, SENA, or other public funding applies;
- accessibility of the training platform and assessment process;
- whether marketing claims about jobs, commissions, or income are documented.

Avoid programs that promise guaranteed jobs, guaranteed high commissions, guaranteed remote work, guaranteed supplier credentials, or guaranteed business income.

Source set

1. U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Travel Agents: [Source link](#)
2. O*NET OnLine — Travel Agents 41-3041.00: [Source link](#)
3. O*NET employment trends: [Source link](#)
4. CareerOneStop WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: [Source link](#)
5. Canada Job Bank — Travel consultant summary / NOC 64310: [Source link](#)
6. Canada Job Bank — Travel consultant wages: [Source link](#)
7. Government of Canada — Training: [Source link](#)
8. Government of Canada — EI and training: [Source link](#)
9. Government of Canada — Labour Market Agreements: [Source link](#)
10. SENA Betowa — Servicios de agencias de viajes: [Source link](#)
11. SENA Betowa — Manejo de la información turística: [Source link](#)
12. SENA Betowa — Fundamentación en gestión del turismo: [Source link](#)
13. SENA Betowa — Buenas prácticas en turismo sostenible para agencias de viajes operadoras: [Source link](#)
14. Indeed U.S. travel-agent salary estimate: [Source link](#)
15. Indeed Colombia city salary comparison: [Source link](#)
16. Indeed Bogotá travel-agent posting example: [Source link](#)

Important notice

This guide provides general educational and career-planning information. It does not guarantee employment, income, admission, funding, certification, licensing, visa approval, travel-document approval, supplier acceptance, or any other result. Requirements, fares, supplier rules, compensation, training availability, entry rules, and opportunities change. Verify consequential decisions with current official sources and authorized professionals.

This controlled edition has not been independently certified by a human translation agency, accessibility auditor, lawyer, immigration professional,

travel regulator, financial adviser, or accreditation body unless separate documentation states otherwise.

License and attribution

Created and directed by **Alberto “Al” Leiva** with AI-assisted research, organization, editing, and document preparation under the author's direction. Unless a file states otherwise, this material is licensed under **CC BY-NC-SA 4.0**.